gatekeeper or as a springboard for African migrants to Europe, at times in an embarrassing way for Europe. Even worse was the well-known fate of Syria.

It soon became obvious that it was not possible to replicate what had happened in Central Europe in the Arab world and that perhaps it should not even have been attempted. And not only that. The failed Arab Spring and the resulting ongoing civil strife, aided by the global availability of social media and even climate change, led to a surge of migrants.

The time of velvet revolutions was over – or so it seemed. Even in Europe's immediate vicinity like Georgia and Ukraine, where another revolution, the so-called Maidan Uprising of 2013, aimed to set the country on a pro-European path. This too, however, was followed by Russian intervention and annexation of the Crimea peninsula in 2014 (and later by even more direct aggression in February 2022). So the embrace of liberal democracy was difficult not only in the Middle East, but on Europe's periphery too, as it seemed to stand in the way of Putin's Russia and his way of thinking. Russia was more and more resembling the Soviet Union – something Putin actually wanted, as his grievances over the collapse of the socialist empire suggest. Events in Belarus in 2020 were another reminder that, what, in the first part of this book, I termed 'Eastern Europe proper', would also not have the same easy way to democracy and full sovereignty as Central Europe: Russia would not let them slip easily out of the Soviet orbit, now being remade by Putin. The window, let open by Gorbachev, was closing indeed and that was the message to the democrats (and, as encouragement, to autocrats too) around the world. After all, Russians themselves could get ideas, should democratic movements in neighbouring countries actually succeed.

The leaders in Central Europe were aware of all that; they also noted that in the US, both Donald Trump's Republicans and the Democrats of Joe Biden do not believe in regime change anymore, at least not in an engineered one. But they still feared Putin's Russia – for a good reason, as demonstrated in Georgia, Ukraine and even Syria.

There was also another, much more subtle message from these developments, including one from the economic crisis that Central Europeans took with them: that they are much more on their own, both in the world and within the EU. And that Western liberal democracy has given